

ELLEN TONG

50 Prospect St Apt 1910, Somerville, MA 02143 | +1 (628) 233-0644
ellentong528.github.io | ellentong@gse.harvard.edu

EDUCATION

HARVARD GRADUATE SCHOOL OF EDUCATION

CAMBRIDGE, MA

MASTER OF EDUCATION, HUMAN DEVELOPMENT AND EDUCATION

Aug 2025 – May 2026 (expected)

- Cumulative GPA: 4.00/4.00
- Relevant Coursework: Latent Variable Analysis: Structural Equation Modeling, Applied Statistical Data Analysis in Psychology II (audit), Intermediate to Advanced Statistical Methods for Applied Educational Research, Curiosity in Learning and Development, How People Learn

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA AT BERKELEY, COLLEGE OF LETTERS & SCIENCE

BERKELEY, CA

BACHELOR OF ARTS, PSYCHOLOGY (*with a minor in Education*)

Aug 2021 – May 2025

- Recipient of the 2025 Departmental Citation
- Cumulative GPA: 3.97/4.00
- Major GPA: 4.00/4.00
- Relevant Coursework: Developmental Psychology, Methods in Cognitive Development, Research & Data Analysis in Psychology, Social Psychology, Developmental Psychopathology, Language Acquisition

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant | Principal Investigator: Dr. Jesse Snedeker

CAMBRIDGE, MA

SNEDEKER LAB, DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY, HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Aug 2025 – Present

- Investigated infants' ability to compose nonlinguistic physical functions (e.g., pushing, smashing) using a novel function-composition paradigm to test whether compositional thought precedes compositional language.
- Supported a Ph.D. researcher with weekly participant-recruitment operations, including outreach, scheduling, and database management through FileMaker, Children Helping Science, and Lookit.
- Co-developed the research assistant manual as the lead RA on this project to onboard and train incoming team members.
- Examined preliminary data indicating that infants as young as 9–11-month-old can compose physical functions and anticipate order-dependent outcomes.

Collaborator & Research Assistant | Principal Investigator: Dr. Ying Xu

CAMBRIDGE, MA

CHILD-CENTERED AI LAB, HARVARD GRADUATE SCHOOL OF EDUCATION

Aug 2025 – Present

- Examined how social-verbal cues implying human-likeness shape children's judgments about the accuracy and source (AI vs. human) of information from a voice-based agent.
- Co-developed study stimuli using ElevenLabs and ChatGPT and co-designed the full online experiment in Gorilla.
- Piloted the initial study with 100+ participants and refined the paradigm into pilot version 2 based on data and feedback.

Honors Thesis Student | Principal Investigator: Dr. Fei Xu

BERKELEY, CA

BERKELEY EARLY LEARNING LAB, DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY, UC BERKELEY

Jun 2024 – May 2025

- Examined deductive reasoning development in 3-year-olds through a gumball game using disjunctive syllogisms.

- Examined the development of posterior probability reasoning in 3-6-year-olds through a block game; piloted four versions of the posterior probability study with 60+ children, refining scripts and PowerPoint animations to enhance designs and participant engagement.
- Cleaned and analyzed data for the probability updating study using tidyverse, ggplot2, lme4, and rstatix; analyzed performance against chance with Wilcoxon tests and identified potential age, order, and learning effects via generalized linear mixed-effects models.
- Discovered that children as young as 3 can form logical thoughts; and that children as young as 5 can update probabilities supporting rational decision-making.

Research Assistant | Principal Investigator: Dr. Steven Piantadosi

BERKELEY, CA

COMPUTATION AND LANGUAGE LAB, DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY, UC BERKELEY

Sep 2023 – May 2024

- Tracked the development of 4-8-year-olds' algorithmic reasoning skills, essential to early math learning, using stories in which animals executed procedures corresponding to algorithms (e.g., maximum, rejection sampling, etc.).
- Recruited 20+ study participants monthly from local museums, parks, and lab settings; handled all recruitment tasks including outreach, scheduling, session management, and data entry
- Recorded and coded video data in Excel, documenting participants' responses to questions and visualizing accuracy rate by age range.
- Identified an increasing above-chance correctness rate with age in the maximum and sorting paradigms, suggesting that by age 4, children exhibit non-numerical abilities crucial for developing math skills.

Mentored Student Researcher | Instructor: Dr. Libby Gerard

BERKELEY, CA

WEB-BASED INQUIRY SCIENCE ENVIRONMENT (WISE) RESEARCH, UC BERKELEY

Feb 2023 – May 2023

- Conducted an independent project evaluating the efficacy of a chatbot "buddy" designed to help students grasp natural science concepts, such as thermodynamics and urban heat islands.
- Developed evaluation methodologies and criteria, tracking student response accuracy before and after using the chatbot to assess its impact on learning.
- Analyzed students' post-chatbot questions, revealing that student-teacher interaction is crucial for addressing unique ideas and providing adaptive, personalized guidance.
- Presented findings in a 23-page essay and at an end-of-year poster session at the Berkeley School of Education.

PUBLICATIONS

Alderete S., **Tong, E.**, Cao, A., Piantadosi, S. & Xu, F. Young Children's Understanding of Prior and Posterior Probabilities. *46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society; July-August 2025; San Francisco, CA.*

Tong, E. Young Children's Understanding of Posterior Probabilities: An Honors Thesis; University of California, Berkeley; May 2025; Berkeley, CA. [[thesis](#); [poster](#)]

HONORS AND AWARDS

Phi Beta Kappa, University of California, Berkeley

Mar 2025 - Present

Departmental Citation in Psychology, University of California, Berkeley

May 2025

- Awarded to the top undergraduate (1/~500) in the Psychology Department based on all aspects of academic life including: research, coursework, writing, and service to the university.

Commencement Speaker, Department of Psychology, University of California, Berkeley

May 2025

- The recipient of the Departmental Citation delivers the commencement speech.

Highest Honors in Psychology, University of California, Berkeley

May 2025

- A distinction granted to students who complete the department's honors program and satisfy rigorous faculty criteria for research and academic excellence.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

HARVARD COLLEGE DEAN OF STUDENTS OFFICE

CAMBRIDGE, MA

Graduate Assistant for Pre-Orientation Programs

Jul 2025 – Present

- Design, implement, and assess the Pre-Orientation Leader Training for 300+ undergraduate student leaders.
- Support the 6 Pre-Orientation Programs' recruitment and registration processes for student leaders and participants.
- Organize and attend planning meetings with staff, relevant colleagues, and students to develop plans for semester events.

NEW ORIENTAL EDUCATION & TECHNOLOGY GROUP

BEIJING, CHINA

Overseas Department Intern

Jun 2023 – Aug 2023

- Assisted in organizing two college essay workshops for 30 high school seniors.
- Enhanced applicant competitiveness through discussions and by providing feedback for three students, resulting in polished essays.

LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

ASSOCIATED STUDENTS OF THE UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA (ASUC)

BERKELEY, CA

ASUC Senator & 501(c)(3) Board of Directors

Jun 2022 – May 2025

- Elected to one of the 20 Senate seats by over 800 undergraduate students and endorsed by the East Asian community to expand access to campus resources by spearheading 10+ programs and campaigns.
- Served on the organization's Board of Directors, fostering connections with administrators, educators, professionals, and student groups through formal collaborations and weekly Senate sessions.
- Established office talent pipelines by providing institutional knowledge training and workshops for community members.

CHINESE PEOPLE UNION AT UC BERKELEY

BERKELEY, CA

Chair

Feb 2022 – May 2025

- Organized annual "KCON" singing competitions for 2 consecutive years, with 300+ attendees and 10+ singers each year.
- Coordinated & hosted the 2024 New Year Gala w/ 200+ attendees, enhancing cohesion between students who attended.
- Designed 500+ event tickets using Canva and Adobe Photoshop to distribute to the Chinese student communities.

SPRING FOUNDATION AT UC BERKELEY

BERKELEY, CA

Vice President & Project Lead

Jan 2022 – Jan 2024

- Led a team of six to organize and host an annual public roundtable event, the Education Charity Dinner Project.
- Connected with three Bay Area NGOs and drafted proposals for collaborative roundtables with each.
- Arranged 10 social events, regular retreats, and four group activities to foster cohesion among club members.

VOLUNTEER EXPERIENCE

OAKLAND PUBLIC EDUCATION FUND

OAKLAND, CA

Teaching Assistant, Second Grade

Jan 2023 – May 2023

- Transformed 10+ lectures into gamified mini lessons to increase engagement for 24 K-2 students.
- Collaborated with teachers to administer monthly language and math assessments to identify future teaching focuses.
- Synthesized 10+ comprehensive reports summarizing student assessment results and the efficiency of interactive teaching.

WEST COUNTY MANDARIN SCHOOL

PINOLE, CA

Teaching Assistant, Kindergarten & First Grade

Jan 2023 – May 2023

- Offered real-time, hands-on support for K–1 class; actively contributed by providing interactive learning activities.
- Created captivating Mandarin lessons and wrote a creative learning guidebook to drive dynamic classroom conversations.
- Assessed students' Mandarin literacy growth by capturing insights through 8 weekly field notes on dominant discourses.

STILES HALL

BERKELEY, CA

Socioemotional Learning (SEL) Mentor, Fourth Grade

Jan 2022 – May 2022

- Initiated 10+ engaging two-hour sessions that delve into diverse academic and everyday subjects for enriched experiences.
- Probed mentees' perspectives on mental wellness and guided them through five activities to enhance self-awareness.

SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Programming languages: R (familiar); Python (intermediate); JavaScript (entry-level)

Computer and online software: Qualtrics; FileMaker Pro; Microsoft Office 365; Google Workspace; Canva; Adobe Photoshop

Miscellaneous: public speaking; extensive experience in student governance and leadership; extensive experience working with children; student advocacy; funding advocacy; legal writing

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native); English (bilingual to native proficiency)